

Escalation Process

What are escalations?

Escalations are support requests that can't be resolved by the support team. These requests require product and engineering support in order to complete.

Why do we need an escalation process?

Escalations are not planned work and they interrupt planned work. When they happen too much, that puts feature work at risk and as such, puts customer happiness and revenue at risk. In order to understand the impact of this unplanned work, we need to be able to visualize and report on it. By creating a process around escalations and using tools like Jira, we can create dashboards and reports that give us insight into the impact of support requests.

Purpose

- Creating a consistent path from PPI request into Engineering
- Make triage ownership visible
- Separate intake from accepted work
- Keep the PPI ticket aligned with the Escalation lifecycle

Design Principals

- Create the Escalation ticket early. Creation means an engineering escalation has entered intake; it does not mean Engineering has accepted work.
- Make triage an explicit on-call responsibility. A newly created Escalation is visible immediately and the on-call engineer is notified that it requires triage.
- Separate triage from prioritization. Triage decides whether Engineering should do work. Prioritization decides when accepted work should happen.
- Use the Escalation ticket as the authoritative engineering lifecycle. The constrained PPI workflow receives a simplified projection of meaningful engineering state changes.
- Require validation before successful completion. Failed validation returns to the work loop.
- Resolve rather than simply close. Terminal Escalations carry an explicit resolution such as Done, Duplicate or Won't Do.

How the process works

1. Route and create

A PPI ticket starts the process. If the responsible team can be determined, automation creates an Escalation ticket and links it to the PPI ticket. Otherwise the responsible team is selected first. When a PPI ticket gets updated, the automation checks for an existing linked Escalation before creating another and validates team assignment.

2. Notify and triage

The Escalation is created in the New status and the team's on-call Slack channel is notified. The notification is an operational handoff: the on-call engineer owns getting the ticket out of New and performing triage but they can get help from others as needed while triaging.

3. Confirm ownership and information

During triage the engineer confirms that the ticket belongs to the team and whether enough information exists to make a disposition. Incorrect routing returns to team selection. Missing information moves the ticket to Needs More Info and then back to triage when supplied.

4. Decide whether work is required

Once enough information exists the engineer decides whether this Escalation should proceed as engineering work. If not, resolve it with the appropriate disposition such as Duplicate or Won't Do. If work is required, proceed to prioritization.

5. Prioritize accepted work

Prioritization answers when the work should happen. Valid work can remain in the backlog for later consideration or enter the work queue now. Backlog items enter the same work queue when later selected through normal team prioritization. It is normal, and encouraged, for the product manager and engineering manager to help with prioritization.

6. Work and validate

Engineering performs the work and validates or reviews the result. The exact Jira path depends on the change. Code may require review and testing; data or configuration changes may require verification. Failed validation identifies remaining work and returns to the work step.

7. Resolve

Successfully validated work resolves as Done. Tickets exiting during triage use the appropriate non-work resolution. Resolving the Escalation then drives the appropriate resolution or update of the linked PPI ticket.

Step Definitions and Automation

Step	Primary owner	Purpose	Rules / automation
Team?	Automation / intake	Determine initial routing.	Use a clearly defined field or rule. If routing cannot be determined, require manual team selection.
Create / Update Escalation	Automation	Establish engineering record.	Link to PPI; check for an existing linked Escalation; validate/update team assignment.
Notify On-Call Slack	Automation	Make triage work visible.	Notify the established on-call channel after creation so a New ticket is known to require triage.
Triage Escalation	On-call engineer	Evaluate request.	Move out of New; evaluate ownership, information, and disposition. Product supports when needed.
Team Confirmed?	On-call engineer	Verify ownership.	Initial routing decides where to send it; this check confirms the receiving team accepts ownership.
Enough Info to Triage?	On-call engineer	Determine readiness for disposition.	If no, move to Needs More Info and request what is missing; return to

Step	Primary owner	Purpose	Rules / automation
			triage when supplied.
Is Work Required?	On-call / Product as needed	Decide whether Engineering proceeds.	If no, resolve with the appropriate resolution. If yes, the ticket becomes accepted engineering work.
Prioritize Ticket	Product + Engineering	Decide when accepted work happens.	Later = backlog / Ready for Development. Now = work queue / Selected for Development.
Work Ticket	Engineering	Perform the work.	When active work begins, synchronize PPI to In Development where appropriate.
Validate / Review	Eng / Product / reporter	Confirm outcome.	Use review, testing, or verification appropriate to the change. Failed validation returns to work.
Resolve Escalation	Engineering / workflow	Record terminal outcome.	Set an explicit Jira resolution: Done, Duplicate, Won't Do, or another approved resolution.
Resolve PPI	Automation / PPI owner	Reflect engineering outcome.	Auto-resolve when engineering resolution satisfies the PPI obligation; otherwise update and leave with the appropriate owner.